



△ Oval-cut hematite

Hematite

Hematite is an iron oxide and a relatively abundant mineral. Its name comes from the Greek word for “blood” and although it can be various colours, it always produces a red streak. The reddish appearance of Mars is due to the presence of hematite on its surface and is the reason for its nickname, the “red planet”. As a gemstone material it is dense with a high refractive index. In powdered form it provides the basis for many paints – pigment made from hematite has been found in cave paintings dating back 40,000 years.

Specification

Chemical name Iron oxide | **Formula** Fe_2O_3 | **Colours** Black, grey, silver, red, brown | **Structure** Trigonal | **Hardness** 5.5–6.5
SG 5.1–5.3 | **RI** 2.94–3.22 | **Lustre** Metallic to earthy
Streak Red to reddish brown | **Locations** China, Australia, Brazil, India, Russia, Ukraine, South Africa, Canada, Venezuela, USA, UK

Group of well-formed hematite crystals | Rough

This specimen of hematite has large, well-formed, trigonal crystals of fine cutting material and a bright metallic lustre similar to polished silver.

Good crystal forms



Quartz crystal



Specular hematite | Rough | Specular hematite is hematite that has formed flattened, bright, and lustrous crystals, as in this example with quartz, from Cumbria, UK.

Metallic lustre



Hexagonal specimen | Rough | This gem-quality hematite is well crystallized and exhibits good hexagonal form, with lustrous metallic faces.

Red surface colouring



Uncut hematite | Rough | This blocky specimen of hematite rough consists of a number of needle-like crystals, and shows a deep red colour.

Carved eye



Textured finish

Hematite frog | Carved | Hematite is a popular, inexpensive carving material for objects such as this frog, and has been used in this way since the second millennium BCE.